

GRADE 8 · READING LITERATURE · RL.8.6

What Naomi Already Knew

Analyze how a gap between what the reader knows and what a character knows creates dramatic irony, and explain the humor or suspense that gap produces.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.8.6: Analyze how a gap between what the reader knows and what a character k...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Dramatic irony happens when the reader or audience knows something a character does not. The size and nature of that knowledge gap determines the effect: if the reader worries about what will happen when the truth comes out, dramatic irony creates suspense; if the mismatch itself is amusing, it creates humor.

Modeled Example

In a story, the reader knows a character's "surprise" party has already been ruined by a leaked group chat, but the party planners do not know the guest of honor knows. What effect does this gap most likely create?

It most likely creates humor, since the reader can anticipate the planners' earnest, oblivious effort colliding with the guest of honor's pretending to be surprised, which is an amusing mismatch rather than a dangerous one.

In a different story, the reader knows a character is walking toward a meeting where they will be fired, but the character believes they are being promoted. What effect does this gap most likely create?

It most likely creates suspense or dramatic tension, since the reader anticipates a painful, consequential realization, making the character's confident anticipation uncomfortable to read rather than funny.

What Naomi Already Knew (Part 1)

1. Marcus had planned Naomi's surprise party down to the minute: 6:45, guests arrive and hide; 6:58, Naomi's mom texts the "we're five minutes away" signal; 7:00, lights off; 7:02, Naomi walks in the door and everyone yells "surprise." He had rehearsed his own line, "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?", four times in the mirror that morning.
2. What Marcus did not know was that Naomi had been added to the party-planning group chat by accident two weeks earlier, when her cousin Deion mistyped a phone number by one digit. Naomi had read all one hundred and forty-three messages, including the argument about whether to get a bounce house (no) and Marcus's four separate drafts of his "surprise" line.
3. Naomi had told no one that she knew. Instead, she had spent the two weeks planning something of her own: a fake, elaborately bad birthday outfit — mismatched shoes, a shirt on inside out, hair deliberately disheveled — designed to make it look, when she "discovered" the surprise, like she had genuinely been caught completely off guard on her worst-dressed day.
4. At 6:58, her mother's "we're five minutes away" text arrived exactly on schedule. Naomi, sitting in the passenger seat in her deliberately disastrous outfit, felt her phone buzz and had to bite the inside of her cheek to keep from laughing at the message: "ETA 5 min, everyone in position, DO NOT respond to this text Naomi might see your phone light up."

What Naomi Already Knew (Part 2)

5. Marcus, hiding behind the couch with eleven other classmates, whispered the countdown under his breath: three, two, one. The lights were off. Someone's elbow was uncomfortably close to someone else's ear. He could hear his own heartbeat, certain this was going to be the best surprise anyone at school had ever pulled off.

6. The door opened. Naomi stepped in, took one look at the dark, silent living room, and — right on cue — let her face go slack with theatrical, wide-eyed shock a half second before the lights snapped on and thirty voices screamed "SURPRISE!"

7. She staggered back a step, hand pressed to her chest, and said, in a voice just a little too polished to be spontaneous, "Wait — is this — Marcus, did you plan this?" Marcus beamed, utterly convinced, and delivered his rehearsed line right on cue: "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?"

8. It was not until three weeks later, cleaning out her phone's message drafts, that Naomi accidentally forwarded Deion the wrong screenshot — one of her own texts from the day of the party, timestamped 6:59, that read: "putting on the worst outfit I own, wish me luck." Deion, confused, showed it to Marcus. Marcus read it twice before he understood, and then he laughed so hard he had to sit down.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit plan does paragraph 1 describe Marcus rehearsing?

2. What does the reader learn in paragraph 2 that Marcus does not know throughout the entire party?

Guided Practice

3. At what point does the reader gain more knowledge than Marcus has? Identify the specific paragraph and explain the gap it creates.

4. What explicit plan does Naomi make in paragraph 3 once she knows about the party?

Guided Practice

5. How does paragraph 4's detail about Naomi biting her cheek "to keep from laughing" depend on the reader already knowing what Marcus does not?

6. What does paragraph 5 reveal about Marcus's emotional state right before the surprise, and how does the reader's knowledge from paragraph 2 change how we read it?

Partner Discussion

7. What explicit performance does Naomi give in paragraph 6, and what word in the text signals to the reader that it is not real?

8. Identify the detail in paragraph 7 that most clearly reveals Naomi's reaction is staged, and explain why it is effective without directly stating "she was acting."

Partner Discussion

9. How does the identical repetition of Marcus's rehearsed line, from paragraph 1 to paragraph 7, contribute to the story's humor?

Independent Practice

10. Where does the story's dramatic irony resolve — that is, when does a character other than Naomi finally learn what the reader has known all along?

11. How does the resolution in paragraph 8 shift the story's dramatic irony instead of ending it? Who is now in on the secret, and who might not be?

Independent Practice

12. Compare the tone of paragraphs 5 through 7 (before Marcus learns the truth) to paragraph 8 (after he learns it). How does the dramatic irony shape each tone?

13. If the story had been told entirely from Marcus's point of view, without ever revealing Naomi's group-chat mishap to the reader, how would the story's effect change?

Independent Practice

14. Explain, using at least two specific examples from the text, how this story uses dramatic irony to create humor rather than suspense.

15. What explicit detail in paragraph 2 explains exactly how Naomi ended up in the group chat?

Small-Group Work

16. Why is it significant that Naomi "told no one that she knew" (paragraph 3), for the dramatic irony that follows?

17. What specific physical details does paragraph 3 give about Naomi's planned "disastrous" outfit?

Small-Group Work

18. How does knowing about Naomi's planned outfit (paragraph 3) change how a reader interprets her appearance when she arrives at the party in paragraph 6?

19. What single word does the narrator use in paragraph 6 that most directly tells the reader Naomi's shock is not genuine?

Exit Ticket

20. Describe the moment where the reader's knowledge and Marcus's knowledge are furthest apart. Why is that specific moment the peak of the story's dramatic irony?

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. His line for when Naomi walks in: "Wait, what — you thought I forgot your birthday?", rehearsed four times in the mirror.
2. That Naomi was accidentally added to the party-planning group chat two weeks earlier and has read all 143 messages, including Marcus's rehearsed line.
3. Paragraph 2 creates the gap; the reader learns Naomi already knows about the party, while Marcus continues believing, through paragraphs 5 through 7, that the surprise is genuine.
4. She plans a fake, elaborately bad birthday outfit designed to make her reaction look like genuine surprise on her "worst-dressed day."
5. It is only funny to the reader because they know, as Naomi does, that the "secret" text is not actually secret to her; without that earlier knowledge from paragraph 2, her reaction would not make sense.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. Marcus feels genuine excitement and certainty that this will be "the best surprise anyone at school had ever pulled off"; because the reader already knows the surprise is not a surprise to Naomi, his confidence creates dramatic irony rather than simple excitement.

7. She lets her face go slack with "theatrical, wide-eyed shock," and the word "theatrical" explicitly signals to the reader that her reaction is a deliberate performance, not genuine surprise.

8. The narrator describes her voice as "just a little too polished to be spontaneous," which lets the reader infer she is acting without stating it outright, reinforcing the dramatic irony already established.

9. The reader already knows from paragraph 1 that Marcus rehearsed this exact line, so hearing him deliver it "right on cue" in paragraph 7, believing it to be spontaneous, is funny precisely because the reader knows how planned and unoriginal it actually is.

10. It resolves in paragraph 8, when Marcus accidentally sees Naomi's old text and realizes she knew about the party the whole time.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. Instead of ending the irony, it shifts who holds the knowledge — now Marcus and the reader share full knowledge, while the rest of the party guests may still not know Naomi was never actually surprised, so a new, smaller irony gap remains.

12. Paragraphs 5–7 have a warm, earnest tone built on Marcus's sincere excitement, which the reader enjoys partly because they know something he does not; paragraph 8 shifts to a comedic tone once the gap closes and Marcus himself can finally appreciate the joke.

13. Without paragraph 2's reveal, the story would read as a simple, sincere surprise-party account with no dramatic irony; the humor specifically depends on the reader knowing what Marcus does not, so hiding that information from the reader as well would eliminate the humor entirely.

14. The gap is used for humor rather than suspense because the mismatched knowledge is low-stakes and amusing rather than dangerous — for example, Naomi biting her cheek to avoid laughing at a "secret" text she already knows about (paragraph 4), and Marcus proudly delivering a rehearsed line he believes is spontaneous (paragraph 7) — both moments make the reader smile at the mismatch rather than worry about it.

15. Her cousin Deion mistyped a phone number by one digit, accidentally adding her to the party-planning group chat two weeks earlier.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. It ensures the knowledge gap stays entirely between Naomi and the reader; if she had told even one other character, the irony would involve more people and would likely be discovered before the party itself.

17. Mismatched shoes, a shirt worn inside out, and hair deliberately disheveled.

18. Without that knowledge, a reader might assume Naomi simply looked disheveled from a busy day; knowing it was deliberately planned turns her appearance into part of the joke, reinforcing that her whole "surprised" persona was staged in advance.

19. "Theatrical."

20. The peak is paragraph 7, when Marcus delivers his rehearsed line "utterly convinced" while Naomi performs equally convincing fake surprise; at that exact moment, the reader alone knows both characters are performing for each other, making it the point of maximum gap between what the reader and the characters understand.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer